

SKYBORNE INTERVIEW

REVISION BOOKLET

James George · 45 minutes on Microsoft Teams · Panel typically 1–2: a training captain plus recruitment.

Combines Interview Brief v3 and the Story Bank into one document. Facts verified 14 August 2026 — corrections recorded in the Appendix.

THE RULE THAT GOVERNS EVERY PAGE. *Highlighted brackets* are details only you hold — fill them from memory, never invention. Every story is drilled with follow-ups precisely because invented detail collapses at the second question. The competency being assessed above all others is safety awareness, which is fundamentally the habit of telling the truth when it costs you something.

SETTLE THIS BEFORE YOU REVISE ANYTHING. Your April interview pack describes a different set of experiences from this booklet — a pan-pan weather diversion, an oil-level check before a solo, a thermal collapse on a cross-country, a fleet-records spreadsheet, a misidentified checkpoint. **Confirm each is a real memory before using it.** If any were drafted as illustration rather than recalled, discard them. The seventeen experiences in Part B are enough, and they are yours.

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C1	The full question bank	Everything they might ask, with routing
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—	Appendix	Fact-check record, sources and confidence

THE CRAM CARD

BA's six assessed areas

Motivation for aviation · **Safety awareness** · Teamwork · Problem solving · Learning from feedback · Managing challenges & responsibilities

Named in your invitation email. The closest thing to a published marking scheme you will ever get.

Your eight story titles

01 Frayed cable	Safety, assertiveness
02 Reception — the call	Leadership, delegation
03 Reception — the team	Teamwork, role clarity
04 The deep end	Problem solving, SA
05 The roof tile	Mistake, just culture
06 Gloucester	Feedback, weakness, workload
07 Three jobs	Competing priorities
08 Difficult customer	Communication

PACE — escalation

Probe — ask a question · Alert — state the concern with evidence · Challenge — direct, propose an action · Emergency — take control

Use on hypotheticals only. Never narrate your own stories in PACE terms.

The three sentences that must land

- 1 · "I've paid for every hour myself since I was thirteen."
- 2 · "I stopped my own first solo because a cable wasn't right."
- 3 · "This would accelerate a plan already running — it wouldn't decide whether it continues."

The numbers

Course	~70 weeks, integrated, full time
Phases	28 wk theory · 26 wk SE/CPL · 9.5 wk ME/IR · 0.5 wk UPRT · 3 wk APS MCC
ATPL exams	13
Ground school standard	First series, 85% avg, max 3 resits
CPL & ME/IR	First series pass
Recourse	Max 1
Cohort	8–12
Locations	Gloucestershire · Bournemouth · Vero Beach
Florida phase	26 weeks — six months
Leave during course	None
During training	Accommodation + food allowance, no salary
Starting salary	£37,081 + allowances
Leave once employed	6 weeks — 3 summer, 3 winter
Fleet freeze	6 years short-haul
Allocation	BA Heathrow <i>or</i> Euroflyer Gatwick — not your choice
Cost per cadet	~£100,000, fully funded
2026 scheme	£18m, up to 160 places, 4th year
Applicants	Over 20,000 — "tens of thousands"
Graduates so far	Nearly 50 into BA flight decks
Max attempts at Stage 2	3

The people and the places

Skyborne — founded 2016; Lee Woodward CEO, Tom Misner chairman, Ian Cooper COO. HQ Gloucestershire (Staverton), second base Bournemouth, US base Vero Beach (acquired 2021). UK fleet DA-42 + Zlin Z 242 L, G1000/FADEC. US 60+ Pipers. Sims: 737 MAX, A320, DA-42.

British Airways — formed 1974 (BOAC + BEA), IAG since 2011. Sean Doyle Chairman & CEO; Simon Cheadle Director of Flight Operations. £7bn transformation announced 2024. "Speedbird" = ICAO callsign, from the 1930s Imperial Airways logo.

Last thing before you join

Flying since thirteen. Solo at fourteen. A hundred hours across five types. PPL in minimum hours. Nine exams first time. All of it paid for out of a business you built and a forty-hour week. You stopped your own first solo because a cable wasn't right.

You are not hoping to be found suitable. Slow down about 15%, say "I", and let them see it.

THE ESSENTIALS

What must be in your head. Set pieces and scenarios outrank stories here, because they are the questions you are certain to be asked.

A1

The marking scheme

Most candidates prepare by guessing what will be assessed. **You have been sent the list.** Your invitation names six areas and states you may draw on education, work, hobbies, volunteering or personal experiences. It recommends STAR explicitly.

AREA BA NAMED	YOUR PRIMARY MATERIAL	STATUS
Motivation for aviation	Gliding from 13, solo at 14, self-funded throughout	Ready
Safety awareness	Frayed winch cable on your first solo	Strongest in the bank
Teamwork	Reception incident, teamwork cut	Ready
Problem solving	The boy in the deep end	Ready
Learning from feedback	Rushing into Gloucester	Ready
Managing challenges & responsibilities	Business + lifeguarding + funding a PPL	Needs your decisions — B2/07

Two readings of that email. It says nothing about the course, the school or the airline — the centre of gravity is unmistakably *you*. So weight rehearsal roughly **70% stories and set pieces, 30% facts**; the facts are insurance against a question that may not come. But "areas such as" is non-exhaustive and a training captain may well ask why Skyborne — so hold A5. And **volunteering is on their named list**, and BA's FAQ calls it a strong addition: frame your winch driving and cable retrieving as unpaid club service that keeps an operation running, at least once.

The nine competencies underneath

BA's six are plain English. Underneath sits the **EASA/ICAO nine-competency framework** every airline now trains and assesses against. An ab-initio interview asks about lifeguarding and roofs because those experiences *predict* these nine. Hold this in reserve — deploy the names only if asked directly about CRM or competency frameworks.

COMPETENCY	ON A FLIGHT DECK	YOUR EVIDENCE
KNO Application of Knowledge	Applying what you know, not reciting it	Nine PPL exams first time · explaining the diving rule from the injury mechanism
PRO Procedures & Compliance	Following SOPs when nobody would notice if you didn't	Winch cable · alarm before entry · roof tile
COM Communication	Clear, verified, two-way; briefings and handovers	Briefing the receptionist · paramedic handover
FPA Flight Path — Automation	Managing and monitoring automation	Thin, and fine at ab-initio. If pushed: G1000 exposure, and that monitoring is the skill that decays
FPM Flight Path — Manual	Handling, energy management	Gliding — 100 hrs solo, five types, no engine
LTW Leadership & Teamwork	Leading, following, delegating, speaking up	Reception · club service · cadets · the business
PSD Problem Solving & Decisions	Deciding on incomplete information, then reviewing	Deep end · winch cable
SAW Situation Awareness	Noticing, projecting forward, knowing what you don't know	Deep end · aircraft low over the threshold
WLM Workload Management	Prioritising, shedding, sequencing, staying ahead	Gloucester · reception task-split · three jobs

If they ask why a lifeguard makes a pilot: *"The competencies airlines assess aren't really about aeroplanes — they're about noticing early, deciding on incomplete information, communicating so the other person actually has it, and protecting the procedure when it's inconvenient. I've been doing all four for money since I was sixteen, just at pool level rather than flight level."*

A2

How to answer

Your ATPL scholarship feedback devoted an entire section to communication, and it is the most transferable part of that letter: **you are marked on how you answer as much as on what you describe.**

THE FOUR NAMED FAILURE MODES

FAILURE	THE FIX
Answers that ran too long	90 seconds to two minutes. Time yourself aloud.
Background before the point	Cut the Situation ruthlessly. Two sentences of context, then what you did.
Broad or generic responses	Where a specific personal example exists, use it.
Not answering the question asked	Listen for the competency, <i>then</i> pick. Eight stories only help if you route correctly.

STAR — AND THE SHARE OF AIRTIME

ELEMENT	WHAT GOES IN	SHARE
Situation	Where, when, who. Enough to make sense of it.	15%
Task	What specifically was yours to own	15%
Action	What you did, step by step. Say "I".	55%
Result	Outcome, then the transferable lesson	15%

SOAR — Situation, **O**bstacle, Action, Result — is offered in your ATPL feedback and is sometimes sharper, because "obstacle" gets you to the Action faster than "task". Use whichever does.

How moulding works — the mechanism that makes eight stories cover twenty questions

In one line: the facts never change — the **opening sentence** and the **closing line** change, and you re-weight which two or three Actions you dwell on.

ELEMENT	CHANGES?	WHY
Situation & facts	Never	Bending facts to fit is how candidates get caught. If it doesn't fit, use another story.
Opening sentence	Always	Names the competency back to them in five seconds, so the assessor knows which box to write in. Highest-leverage sentence in any answer.
Which Actions you dwell on	Yes	Same six things you did; airtime goes to the two that evidence <i>this</i> competency.
Closing line	Always	The lesson is what gets written down. It must fit the question asked, not the one you rehearsed most.

Two hard limits. (1) One event, one use per interview. Tell the reception incident as leadership and it is spent — teamwork must come from elsewhere. **(2) Don't reuse a closing construction.** The winch cable and the deep end both close on asymmetric consequences. Use that reasoning once; twice reads as a formula rather than as how you think.

Also: don't volunteer the aviation parallel unless asked — let them make it, it lands better. And **prepare the drill questions, not just the story:** composure when challenged is the assertiveness competency.

A3

The set pieces

Six questions are effectively guaranteed. These are the only ones worth polishing to near-script — everything else should be fluent, not memorised. **Learn the beats, not the words.** An interviewer who has heard four hundred of these spots recitation instantly: the rhythm changes and the eye contact goes.

1 · Tell us about yourself — ninety seconds

Three beats: who you are now, the thread that led to flying, where you are in the process. Not a CV read aloud. **The only question you are certain to get — rehearse it hardest.**

"I'm James, I'm [age], and I've been flying since I was thirteen. I started gliding at [club], went solo at fourteen, and I've got around a hundred hours solo now across five different types.

Alongside that I run my own exterior cleaning business, which I started partly because flying is expensive and I wanted to pay for it myself. I've also been lifeguarding around forty hours a week — and between the two of those I funded my PPL, which I finished in minimum hours, and passed all nine CAA ground exams first time.

The club side matters to me as much as the flying does. I drive the winch and retrieve cables, because a gliding club doesn't get airborne unless someone does the unglamorous jobs.

So — flying is the only thing I've ever really worked towards, and so far I've been paying for it a job at a time. Speedbird would let me do it properly."

That last line answers "why this scheme" before they ask, and connects to Sean Doyle's stated purpose in funding the academy — removing cost as the barrier — without quoting him at them.

2 · Why do you want to be a pilot?

"I've loved planes since I was little" is what every candidate says and is not an answer on its own. **Pair the origin with something adult** — what appeals now that you understand the job. You have the rarest possible version: you started at thirteen and have spent your own money on it ever since. **Someone who paid for it themselves does not have to argue that they mean it.**

Have one adult reason ready and make sure it's actually true for you: the responsibility; the fact that competence is checked and re-checked for your whole career; the combination of technical skill and working with people you've never met before.

3 · Why British Airways?

Specifics, not sentiment: the flag carrier's role, the network scale, short-haul-then-long-haul progression after the six-year freeze, the £7bn transformation programme. Then the personal hook — **one sentence, not a paragraph**: you are precisely the person the academy exists for.

Quoting BA's mission statement back at an interviewer lands flat. Your best "why BA" material is Doyle's line about removing cost as a barrier — **because you are the case**. You funded flying from a business you built and a forty-hour week. You aren't describing the scheme's purpose in the abstract; you are the reason it exists. Say it once, plainly.

4 · Why Skyborne, over FTEJerez?

This is their interview and it is the question they most want answered well. Your strongest angle is one almost no other candidate has:

"I've come up through a gliding club, so I know exactly what a club environment is — and it's brilliant for some things. But it's informal, and everything I've read about Skyborne is about mirroring an airline from day one. I want to make that step deliberately rather than pick it up later.

The other specific is Bournemouth. Most training happens at quiet fields. I did my PPL navigation into Gloucester and the busiest, most demanding flying I've done is the flying that taught me the most — so an airport with commercial traffic, ILS approaches and proper RT is something I actively want, not something I'd tolerate."

Fleet, cohort size and locations are supporting detail if they probe — but **say what each one means for how you learn**, never just list them.

New follow-up you must be ready for — "why integrated with us rather than the modular route?" Aeros delivers modular elements within this same funded academy, and you hold a PPL, which makes you exactly the profile that route exists for. So:

"I've done the modular thing already, in miniature — I funded a PPL in pieces around a job and a business, and I know what it costs you in continuity. You lose time to rescheduling and you re-learn things you'd have retained if the phases ran together. Integrated is seventy weeks of momentum with a cohort of eight to twelve going at the same pace. Having done it the fragmented way, I'd choose the continuous one deliberately."

That answer is only available to you *because* you self-funded.

5 · What if you don't get a place?

Resilience — and the most important framing in this booklet. Your ATPL feedback put it perfectly: the panel wants evidence that funding would **accelerate a plan already in motion, rather than determine whether the plan can continue at all.**

"I'd keep going, slower. I'd carry on building the business, keep flying, keep applying — I'm already going after ATPL theory funding separately, and I'd apply here again. It would set me back a couple of years, not stop me.

I've been paying for this myself since I was thirteen, so the plan doesn't depend on somebody funding it. This would accelerate it."

A candidate whose whole plan collapses without the scheme reads as someone who will fold at the first progress-check failure. Yours demonstrably doesn't. Mention you'd ask for feedback and act on it — BA gives it at this stage.

6 · What do you most want us to remember about you?

You were asked a version of this at the ATPL interview, and the feedback is explicit: repeating that you are passionate about aviation is the weak answer. It wants something **specific** that gives the panel a reason to argue for you once you've left the call.

"That I've been flying since I was thirteen and I've paid for every hour of it myself — out of a business I built and a forty-hour week alongside it. Nobody has funded me to get this far.

So I don't think you'd be taking much of a chance on whether I'd put the work in."

Then stop talking. Two sentences, delivered evenly, and let the silence sit. The instinct will be to soften it or add to it — don't. This is the last thing they'll write down.

A 4

CRM, PACE and the scenarios

Your ATPL panel asked you two specific airline scenarios and told you afterwards what a strong answer looked like. **Assume they come again** — and note that "safety awareness" is the second item on British Airways' own list. These want your **reasoning aloud**, not a STAR answer.

A note on that feedback letter. It is a generic template sent to all unsuccessful candidates — no scores, no remarks about you. So don't read "some candidates gave overly long answers" as criticism of your performance; you don't know that. What it gives you is more useful than personal feedback: **it is the panel's actual rubric**. Read every "strong candidates did X" as the bar, and clear it.

PACE — the escalation model

Very few ab-initio candidates can name a structured escalation model. You can.

STEP	WHAT IT IS	SOUNDS LIKE
P — Probe	Ask a question. Invites them to check, with no challenge in it.	"What approach are we planning?"
A — Alert	State the concern with your evidence.	"I'm concerned — the ATIS I copied gave the RNAV as the approach in use."
C — Challenge	Direct, unambiguous, <i>and propose an action</i> .	"Captain, I don't believe that's the procedure in use. I'd like to confirm with ATC before we descend."
E — Emergency	Take action. Reserved for when safety is about to be compromised and nothing else has worked.	"Stop — I am taking control."

How to use it, and how not to. Use PACE on the **hypotheticals**. Do **not** retrofit it onto your winch cable story — let that stand as something you actually did and let the panel notice for themselves that it was a real-world escalation. Naming the model over your own lived experience sounds rehearsed; using the model on a hypothetical *and* having the experience underneath it shows you understand both theory and practice. That combination is rare at your stage.

Scenario one — the captain briefs the wrong approach

"You're a newly qualified First Officer. During descent the Captain begins briefing an approach you believe isn't the procedure in use. You raise it once and he dismisses it. What do you do?"

1. **Start with the principle.** Being junior doesn't remove my responsibility for the safety of the flight. Strong candidates led with that sentence.
2. **Check yourself first.** Am I actually sure? What's my evidence — the ATIS, the clearance, the chart, the FMS? I'm new, and it's possible I'm the one who's wrong. Being assertive about a hunch is not the same skill.
3. **Escalate through PACE.** I've probed and been dismissed, so the next step is to alert with the evidence rather than repeat the same statement louder.

- 4. **Bring in a third source rather than making it two opinions.** Asking ATC to confirm the approach in use turns it from my word against his into a fact neither of us owns. That removes the personal dimension entirely.
- 5. **Be explicit about where the line is.** If it stayed unresolved and we were about to fly an approach I believed was wrong, I would say so unambiguously and I would not simply let it happen.
- 6. **Afterwards.** Debrief on the ground — not as a complaint, but because that's how both of us learn which was right. A wider pattern is what the reporting system is for.

Note point 4. It's the same instinct as your winch cable: you didn't argue the point, you proposed the other line. Finding the option that removes the conflict rather than winning it is a recognisable strength of yours — and if the panel connects the two, that's a very good moment.

Scenario two — the captain who cuts small corners

"A Captain you fly with regularly makes small deviations from SOPs. Nothing obviously dangerous. What do you do?" — the subtler one. Your feedback is explicit that **two opposite answers both lose marks**: ignoring it because he's more experienced, and immediately escalating something minor without considering a proportionate response.

- 1. **Name the real risk.** Any single deviation may not be dangerous. The problem is that repeated non-compliance **normalises** poor practice and quietly erodes the margins SOPs exist to protect. The concept is **normalisation of deviance** — margins disappear gradually and nobody notices the day they ran out. Naming it is worth a mark.
- 2. **Gather facts, avoid assumptions.** I'm new. Is it actually a deviation, a company variation, or something I've misunderstood?
- 3. **The first step is a conversation, not a report.** Ask directly and without accusation, at a quiet moment rather than mid-sector. Often that resolves it — and sometimes I'd learn something.
- 4. **Escalate proportionately** if it continues or is significant, using the airline's confidential reporting or management process. In a just culture that isn't an attack on him; it's the mechanism working as designed.
- 5. **Say the uncomfortable part plainly.** Seniority doesn't make something safe. If I said nothing because he outranked me, I'd be part of the problem.

Four concepts to be able to talk about

CONCEPT	WHAT TO BE ABLE TO SAY
SOPs	They let two pilots who have never met operate safely together, because both know what the other will do next. They also encode lessons learned the hard way — most of them exist because something went wrong once.
CRM	Using all available resources — the other pilot, cabin crew, ATC, the manuals — rather than relying on individual technical skill. Communication, teamwork, situational awareness, workload management, decision-making, leadership, fellowership and assertiveness.
TEM	Threat and Error Management. Threats come from outside the crew — weather, terrain, ATC, tech problems, time pressure. Errors come from the crew. The job is to anticipate threats, catch errors early, and stop either becoming an undesired aircraft state. Briefing an approach is TEM in practice — naming the threats before they arrive.
Just Culture	Honest errors reported openly are not punished, because a system that punishes reporting simply stops hearing about problems. Wilful violations and negligence still are. The point is that safety depends on people telling you things they don't have to.

Your just-culture example is already in the bank — the roof tile. You self-reported damage that was invisible from the ground and would never have been traced to you. That is just culture told from the inside, and it is more convincing than any definition you could recite.

FOLLOWERSHIP — THE HALF NOBODY PREPARES

Your feedback lists followership alongside leadership. Worth one line if it fits: a good first officer isn't only someone who can speak up — it's someone who **supports the captain's decision once it's made**, monitors actively rather than passively, and doesn't need to be right. Most candidates only prepare the assertive half.

A5

The facts

BA's invitation doesn't mention the school, the course or the airline — so this is **insurance**, not the centre of gravity. But a training captain may ask, and vagueness about the flight school is the fastest way to look like any school would do. Hold it; don't lead with it.

WHAT ASSERTIVENESS ACTUALLY MEANS HERE

Defined precisely in your feedback, and it isn't what most people think: **expressing an opinion with conviction, explaining your reasoning, and remaining composed when challenged or questioned further.** Note the last part — that is what the drill questions test. Being unshakeable for two minutes and then wobbling under "what if you'd been wrong?" is the failure mode. The right response: *"Then I'd have been wrong — and I'd rather be wrong out loud at four thousand feet than right and silent."*

The course

PHASE	LENGTH	CONTENT	WHERE
1	28 weeks	Theoretical knowledge — 13 UK CAA ATPL exams	Gloucestershire
2	26 weeks	Single-engine flight training through to CPL	Vero Beach, Florida
3	9.5 weeks	Multi-engine Instrument Rating	Gloucestershire
4	0.5 week	Advanced UPRT	UK
5	3 weeks	APS MCC on Boeing 737 MAX or Airbus A320	UK

BA describes it as a **70-week integrated course requiring full-time attendance, with no annual leave during the course**. Quote the phases *or* the total, not both in a way that invites the subtraction — the balance is transitions and phase gaps.

THE STANDARDS

REQUIREMENT	STANDARD
Ground school	First series pass, 85% average , max 3 resits
CPL	First series pass
ME/IR	First series pass
Recourse	No more than 1
Completion	APS MCC, aUPRT, UK Part-FCL licence

Skyborne's FAQ is explicit: *"Should any of these conditions not be met, British Airways has the right to withdraw the conditional offer of employment."* **Know it, and don't sound frightened of it.**

THE TERMS

TERM	DETAIL
Starting salary	£37,081 p.a. plus allowances once you join
During training	Accommodation + food allowance. No salary.
Annual leave	6 weeks once employed — 3 summer, 3 winter. None during the course.
Fleet freeze	Initial 6 years short-haul; you can bid between BA and Euroflyer within it
Allocation	On business need: Heathrow with BA, or Gatwick with Euroflyer. Not your choice. Confirmed ~3 months before completion.
Type rating	Funded onto a short-haul fleet; you're an employee from that point
Training cost	~£100,000 per cadet, fully funded

A training bond is widely reported but appears nowhere in BA's published FAQ. **Treat any figure as unconfirmed and don't raise it yourself.**

"How would you feel if you were allocated to Euroflyer at Gatwick rather than BA at Heathrow?" The wrong answer is disappointment. The right one: you've read the terms, you understand allocation follows business need, and you can name something genuinely attractive about Euroflyer — a growing operation, a European network, and if it suits you, same-day return flying rather than nightstops. Close by noting you'd be a BA-trained pilot either way, with a route back within the freeze.

Your study answer — and the arithmetic you must do before they do

You passed all nine CAA ground exams first time with a high average, on a deliberate schedule: **one exam a month, one focused hour a day**. Lead with that. Then **do the maths out loud before they do it for you** — one a month is a nine-month rate; ground school is **13 exams in 28 weeks, roughly double**, on materially deeper subjects, to an 85% first-series standard. A training captain will run that calculation while you're still talking.

"My method worked at one a month. Ground school runs at about double that, so here's what I'd change —" then name real changes: active testing and question banks from week one instead of reading; marking yourself hard; keeping a list of question types you get wrong to spot repeats; a study group, because being unable to explain something finds a gap faster than re-reading; and raising a weak subject in week two rather than week six.

Your ATPL feedback says explicitly that **explaining how you approach learning** — rather than stating that you can work hard — is what separates strong candidates.

Know Skyborne

ITEM	DETAIL
Founded	2016, by Lee Woodward with entrepreneur Tom Misner. Woodward is CEO and a former airline pilot; Misner chairman; Ian Cooper COO. Woodward and Cooper both held senior roles at other major airline training academies first.
UK head office	Gloucestershire Airport (Staverton) — ground school and head office. Radar service, instrument approaches, full RNAV, central for cross-country navigation.

Second UK base	Bournemouth Airport — active international airport, ILS and RNAV approaches, commercial airline-style operations.
US base	Vero Beach, Florida — acquired 2021 from Vero Beach Flight Training Academy.
Fleet	UK: Diamond DA-42 twin and Zlin Z 242 L, G1000 glass avionics and FADEC. US: 60+ Piper single- and multi-engine.
Simulators	Boeing 737 MAX, Airbus A320, Diamond DA-42, plus in-house engineering.
Accommodation	Cheltenham: refurbished Regency townhouses in the town centre, en-suite with study areas, communal kitchen per floor; also Pittville Campus. Bournemouth: Kaplan Living. Dedicated accommodation at Vero Beach.
Cohort size	8–12 per course
BA relationship	Approved training partner; ran the first Speedbird interviews at Waterside. BA's FAQ names FTEJerez and Skyborne as the two schools SPA cadets train with.
Other partners	easyJet, Ryanair, Jet2, Wizz Air, TUI, Emerald Airlines, DHL Air, IndiGo cadets, large US student base.
Positioning	Their own language: "setting the standards for professional airline training", in an environment designed to mirror airline operations.

Know the airline

ITEM	DETAIL
Formed	1974, from the merger of BOAC and BEA. Part of International Airlines Group (IAG) since 2011.
Leadership	Sean Doyle, Chairman & CEO. Simon Cheadle, Director of Flight Operations — he fronts the academy announcements.
Bases & sisters	Heathrow (main), Gatwick, London City. BA Euroflyer (Gatwick short-haul, A320 family) and BA CityFlyer (London City, Embraer).
Fleet	A320 family short-haul; A350, A380, Boeing 777 and 787 long-haul. 18 Airbus A350-1000s. Order book includes 777-9s.
Investment	£7 billion transformation programme announced 2024: new aircraft, Club Suite across almost the whole long-haul fleet, lounges, rebuilt website and app, investment at BA Maintenance Cardiff to take the A350. Well into delivery — don't present it as new.
"Speedbird"	BA's ICAO callsign, from the Imperial Airways Speedbird logo of the 1930s.
Doyle on the academy	"By removing the costs, we're opening the opportunity up to more people and making a flying career more accessible to all."
The academy	2026 is the fourth year: £18m, up to 160 places, ~£100,000 per cadet. Nearly 50 graduates already into BA flight decks. Tens of thousands apply each year.

Industry awareness

Your ATPL feedback flagged this as a distinct assessed area. You should be able to answer "**what's caught your eye in aviation recently?**" with something specific, current, and that you have a view on. **Find it yourself in the week before the interview** — anything printed here would be stale, and a story you've genuinely read beats one you've been handed. "**I read that X happened, and what struck me was Y**" beats "I read that X happened."

Reputable sources: FlightGlobal, Aviation Week, Flight Training News, the CAA's own publications, broadsheet aviation coverage. Be careful with aggregators and YouTube — often wrong on detail, and being confidently wrong is worse than saying you hadn't seen it.

THEME	WHAT TO GRASP
Pilot recruitment	Cyclical, and it has swung hard in both directions within recent memory. Schemes like Speedbird exist partly because airlines are securing a pipeline years ahead. Understanding that your career will have cycles in it is a mature thing to be able to say.
Training pathways	Integrated vs modular; self-sponsored vs airline-funded; MPL vs fATPL. You'd be on a fully funded integrated route — knowing what the alternatives cost and demand is part of understanding what you've been offered.
Sustainability	SAF, and fleet renewal as the main near-term lever on emissions — newer aircraft are bought for fuel burn as much as for cabins. BA's A350 and 787 renewal sits inside this.
Technology	Increasing automation and the training question that follows: how you keep manual handling and monitoring sharp when the aircraft flies itself most of the time. This is why UPRT is on your course.
Regulation	Post-Brexit UK CAA divergence from EASA and what it means for licence recognition. You'd hold a UK Part-FCL licence.
Geopolitics	Airspace closures and reroutings add hours and cost to long-haul operations, and can change which routes are viable.

Worth doing before the call if you can: have one proper conversation with a working commercial pilot. Your feedback specifically valued candidates who had. *"I spoke to a first officer at ——— about what the first year is actually like"* is a stronger sentence than anything you can read. Your gliding club and PPL instructors are the obvious route in — many club members fly commercially.

ATPL theory validity — know it in one sentence

Your scholarship panel probed this and it's the obvious follow-up if you mention applying for theory funding separately. **All 13 exams must be completed within 18 months of your first attempt** (max 4 attempts per subject, max 6 sittings); once complete, **passes are valid 36 months** for CPL/IR issue, and thereafter tied to your IR validity for ATPL issue. On Speedbird this is academic — the course runs theory in 28 weeks — but saying it demonstrates you understand the pathway you'd be leaving behind.

Technical — unlikely, but be comfortable

An ab-initio scheme with a GCSE entry bar, so deep technical grilling is improbable — but you hold a PPL and nine ground exams, so they may probe further than with another candidate. Be fluent on: **the four forces**; how a wing generates lift; the three primary controls and their axes; what an ILS gives you; why aircraft take off and land into wind; **what a stall actually is** (angle of attack, not speed); and the winch launch failure drill.

THE EVIDENCE

Your examples. Seventeen real experiences — eight built, seven to build, two in reserve. Each story carries mould lines so one event answers many questions.

B1

The routing table

Listen for the competency, *then* route. Getting this mapping right matters more than the wording of any single answer — your feedback names "not answering the question asked" as a distinct failure mode.

QUESTION	PRIMARY	IF ALREADY SPENT
Spoke up when something wasn't right	01 Frayed cable	HGV defect · roof tile
A significant mistake you made	05 Roof tile	Gloucester (as a habit, not an event)
Difficult feedback / a failure	06 Gloucester	Waterside group exercise reflection
Quick decision, incomplete information	04 The deep end	Winch cable · a gliding decision to come home
Took the lead when nobody else would	02 Reception — the call	Cadets · running the business
Teamwork on something difficult	03 Reception — the team	Busy launch point · cadets · kitchen
Several competing priorities	07 Three jobs at once	Reception (two jobs, one person)
An unhappy or difficult customer	08 Difficult customer	A parent who argued about a rule
Stayed calm when others weren't	02 Reception	The deep end
Noticed something before anyone else	04 The deep end	Aircraft low over the threshold · winch cable
A rule you followed when it was inconvenient	01 Winch cable	Alarm-before-entry · a lifeguarding procedure you held to
Explained something complicated	Briefing the receptionist	Explaining a quote or a process to a customer
A disagreement in a team	Kitchen / workshop / club — build it	Winch cable, if you were pushed back on
Someone you found difficult to work with	Kitchen / workshop — build it	—
Adapting when a plan changed	Weather scrubbing a job day	A gliding day changing · a shift swap absorbed
Put someone else's needs first	Covering a shift	Winch cable, read as the operation over your own solo
Something you're proud of	Building the business that funded the flying	Solo at fourteen
Your biggest weakness	Rushing when behind (Gloucester)	— never invent a safer one
Away from home / independence	Cadets + business + 40-hour weeks	— be honest about what you haven't done
Volunteering	Winch driving & cable retrieving	Club task days

B2

The story bank

Each block: the spine (facts that never change), competency coverage, **moulds** (opening and closing lines by question type), what to fill, and the drills they'll use.

01 · THE FRAYED WINCH CABLE — your strongest asset

PRO PSD SAW LTW COM

Spine. First solo in a glider. Briefed, cleared, sitting in the aircraft. You noticed the winch cable was frayed and tangled. You could have flown — nobody had stopped it, everyone was ready, it was your first solo. You stopped it and told [who]. **The part worth noticing: you didn't just refuse — you asked to be swapped to the other line**, so the day kept running, the queue kept moving, and you still flew. Airborne [when]; delay about [X] minutes.

IF THEY ASK...	OPEN WITH	CLOSE WITH
Spoke up when something wasn't right	"My first solo — years of work to get to that seat, everyone ready, and I'm the one who stopped it."	"A cable failure on a winch launch happens low and fast. Twenty minutes of waiting and the alternative aren't comparable things."
Followed a rule that was inconvenient	"The check nobody watches you do is the one that matters."	"Checks only earn their keep on the day they find something. That was the day."
A difficult decision / one that cost you	"The most expensive decision I've made in aviation cost me my own first solo launch."	"It was the cheapest thing I've ever bought, in hindsight."
Put others ahead of yourself	"I didn't want the launch cancelled — I wanted the risk gone. Those aren't the same request."	"Stopping the day would have been easy and useless. Finding the other line kept everyone flying."
Noticed something others hadn't	"Several people had been past that cable that morning. So had I."	"You don't get credit for noticing — you get credit for what you do in the ten seconds after."
Integrity	"Nobody would have known if I'd just flown it, including me, probably."	"The version of me that flies it is the version that later can't be trusted with anything smaller."
Went against the group	"Everyone was ready. The queue was behind me. That's the pressure, and it's not spoken."	"Being the one who says 'wait' is uncomfortable for about a minute and useful for the rest of your career."

Fill: was checking it your job, or did you just see it? · did anyone push back, even mildly — "it'll be fine", "we've launched on worse"? **Holding a position after a first "no" roughly doubles this story's value** · did the club change anything afterwards?

Drill: "What if someone senior had told you it was fine?" · "How did you know it was unserviceable?" · "Where's the line between assertive and difficult?" · "Has anyone ever challenged you?" · "What if there'd been no second line?"

Why it scores: you stopped your own first solo — the personal cost is enormous and instantly legible to anyone who has flown gliders, which is everyone in that room. And you proposed a workable alternative rather than simply refusing: the entire difference between assertive and obstructive. It will be read as a first officer challenging a captain, because that is exactly what it is.

Do not narrate this in PACE terms. Tell it as what happened.

02 · RECEPTION — THE CALL (leadership cut)

LTW COM WLM PSD

Spine. Lifeguarding at [venue]. A woman in her [age] fell in reception and broke her hip. You were second on scene, with a receptionist who was new and had never dealt with anything like it, a pool still full of swimmers, and nobody formally in charge. You were the trained first aider.

The first thing you did was recognise it was two jobs, not one, and that you couldn't do both. You took the casualty and gave the receptionist the 999 call — but didn't just say "call an ambulance": you told her exactly what to say [where you were, what had happened, the woman's age and condition]. Partly because a panicking person gives a bad handover, and partly because someone with a clear job to do stops panicking. With the casualty the main decision was **not to move her** — suspected hip fracture — so you kept her still, [kept her warm / monitored breathing and colour], and talked to her more or less continuously because [your reason]. The other lifeguard stayed on poolside the whole time. Handover to the paramedics: [how she fell, how long, what you'd done, what you'd deliberately not done].

IF THEY ASK...	OPEN WITH	CLOSE WITH
Took the lead when nobody else would	"Nobody was in charge, and the gap lasted about three seconds before it needed filling."	"Leading wasn't giving orders — it was noticing it was two jobs and that I could only hold one."
Stayed calm when others weren't	"The receptionist was panicking, and the fastest way to stop that wasn't to reassure her."	"Someone with a clear job to do stops panicking. Giving her the call was the calming, not the words."
Several priorities at once	"Two emergencies competing: a casualty in reception, and a pool that hadn't stopped being dangerous."	"Everyone's instinct is to converge on the incident. What made it work was someone staying on the thing that hadn't gone wrong yet."
Explained something complicated	"I didn't tell her to call an ambulance. I told her what to say, in order."	"A panicking person gives a bad handover — so I removed the thinking from the task and left her only the doing."
Communicated under pressure	"The handover to the paramedics was the part I'd thought about while I was waiting."	"What I'd done, and what I'd deliberately <i>not</i> done. The second half is the half people forget to hand over."
Delegation / trusting others	"I gave away the job I'd have found easier and kept the one I was trained for."	"Delegating the thing you'd rather do is usually the tell that you've allocated correctly."

Fill: the four things you told her to say · why you kept talking to the casualty · the outcome for her. (She came back weeks later with flowers and chocolates and thanked you and the receptionist by name.)

Drill: "What if the receptionist had frozen anyway?" · "Why not make the 999 call yourself?" · "Were you actually the right person to take charge?" · "How did you know not to move her?" · "What would you do differently?"

Why it scores: that closing line is *task allocation under load* — what a captain does in an abnormal: fly the aircraft, delegate the radio, don't let both pilots go heads-down on the same problem. The paramedic handover is a second, separate mark; structurally it is a handover briefing. **Say neither of those out loud.**

03 · RECEPTION — THE TEAM (teamwork cut — cannot be used in the same interview as 02)

LTW COM SAW

Same facts, different weighting. Told as leadership it is a story about you; told as teamwork it is a story about three people covering three jobs. **Lead with the split, not with yourself.**

Situation & task. Three of us on shift, an emergency in reception, and a pool full of swimmers that still needed watching. The difficulty wasn't the first aid — it was that the incident was in reception, our actual responsibility was the water, and the emergency was pulling everyone towards it.

Action. **The other lifeguard held the poolside** — that was the discipline in it; the water was still the bigger risk and it stayed covered. **The receptionist took communications** — the 999 call, then [meeting the ambulance / clearing the entrance / keeping people back]. **I took the casualty.** Name what *she* did well, not only what you told her: [what the receptionist got right once she had a job].

Close with: "Nobody allocated those roles — we fell into the right ones. And that only worked because each of us knew the others' jobs well enough not to have to discuss it."

Crediting a named colleague for something specific reads far better than crediting "the team". Teamwork answers usually describe *effort*; this one describes **role clarity under load**, which is far rarer to hear at your stage.

Warning: if they ask leadership and then teamwork, you need a different second story — most likely army cadets, a club task day, or a busy launch point.

Build that reserve.

04 · THE DEEP END

SAW PSD PRO COM

Spine. A swim school session. A boy had just moved up a stage and was in the deep end for the first time; you were on the chair covering that end. He started bobbing and gasping — not shouting, not waving. What told you it was distress rather than messing about was *[vertical in the water, head tipping back, mouth at the waterline, no forward progress]*. It doesn't look like drowning looks on television, which is exactly why you're trained to recognise that specific picture. **You didn't wait to be sure** — *[X]* seconds from noticing to out of the chair. **You hit the emergency alarm before entering the water, not after** — that's the order, because it brings help and gets the rest of the pool covered while you're committed. Got to him, to the side and out within seconds. Then the second half of the job people forget: calming him, and calming his parents, who had watched.

IF THEY ASK...	OPEN WITH	CLOSE WITH
Quick decision, incomplete information	"I was never certain he was drowning. That's the whole point of the story."	"The cost of going early was looking slightly silly. The cost of going late isn't the same size of problem — so they don't get weighted the same."
Noticed something before anyone else	"Drowning doesn't look like it does on television — which is exactly why you're trained to recognise one specific picture."	"Recognition isn't instinct. It's a picture someone taught me, and I'd looked at it a thousand times before it was real."
Followed procedure under pressure	"The instinct is to get in the water. The procedure is to hit the alarm first, and the order matters."	"Committing yourself without telling anyone leaves the rest of the pool uncovered. The alarm is for them, not for me."
Dealing with people who are upset	"Getting him out took seconds. The parents took a lot longer, and that was the actual job."	<i>[what you said to them]</i>

Fill: your recognition cue · seconds elapsed · what you said to the parents · outcome and whether anything changed afterwards.

Drill: "How do you know he wasn't fine?" · "What if you'd been wrong and a parent complained?" · "What if the alarm had brought nobody?" · "Have you got that judgement wrong the other way?"

Why it scores: asymmetric-consequence reasoning — precisely how a go-around decision is framed. Acting early on an ambiguous cue rather than waiting for certainty is one of the most valuable instincts you can show.

Careful: the winch cable closes on the same logic. Use that construction in **one** of them, not both.

05 · THE ROOF TILE

PRO COM PSD LTW

Spine. You run your own exterior cleaning business. Doing a roof clean on *[type of roof / tile]*, you damaged a tile. You couldn't see it from the ground; the customer would never have known — but water ingress was inevitable *[when?]*, and by the time it showed as a leak nothing would have connected it back to you. You noticed *[when — at the time, coming down, reviewing photos?]*. **You told him before you left the site** — not just that you'd cracked a tile, but what would happen if it was left and where it would show up inside. Then offered to go back up and replace it at your own cost, **and to check the rest of the roof while up there** — because if one tile had gone, you wanted to know whether others were weak rather than find out the same way. He thanked you for being honest, tipped you, and left a good review.

IF THEY ASK...	OPEN WITH	CLOSE WITH
A significant mistake	"I broke something a customer would never have found."	"The cheap moment to own a mistake is immediately. The cost of a hidden one grows with time."
Integrity when it cost you	"The whole story is about the ten minutes where nobody would have known."	"The outcome was better than concealing would have been — but that isn't why I did it, and I'd have done it if he'd been furious."
Just culture / self-reporting	"I can give you a definition, but I'd rather give you the time I did it."	"A system only hears about problems if the person who caused one is better off telling you."
A difficult conversation	"I had to go and find him and start with the worst sentence."	"Leading with the consequence rather than the excuse made it a two-minute conversation instead of an argument."
What you changed permanently	"The lesson wasn't 'be careful on roofs'."	<i>[photographing the roof before starting · flagging fragile roofs at quote stage · different access or footing]</i>

Fill — the scored element: what you subsequently changed. Your ATPL feedback is explicit that this is what's marked, so it is **not optional**. Also **be honest about whether you briefly considered saying nothing** — admitting the pull to conceal is what makes this credible. A candidate who has never felt it either hasn't made a mistake that mattered or isn't being straight.

Drill: "What if he'd been furious and refused to pay?" · "Have you ever *not* owned up to something?" · "What would you do if you saw a fellow cadet make an error and say nothing?" · "What did it cost you?"

Why it scores: self-reported before discovery, genuinely concealable, remediated at your own cost, and you went beyond the fault to check for others. The just-culture argument made by demonstration rather than assertion.

06 · GLOUCESTER — HELD BACK — the most efficient story in the bank

WLM KNO PSD COM

Spine. During PPL navigation training, flying into Gloucester — one of the busiest GA airports in the country, radar service, instrument traffic. Your instructor told you he wasn't sending you solo: you were rushing. *[Did it sting? Say so if it did — "I thought I was ready" is more human than pretending you took it perfectly.]* What he'd seen was *[checks run too fast, RT rushed and untidy, three things at once, arriving at the zone boundary unprepared]*. You didn't argue — **you asked what specifically he wanted to see different**, because "slow down" on its own isn't actionable. Then changed things: *[briefing the arrival on the ground before flying it, writing the RT out, working further ahead of the aircraft, doing one thing properly at a time]*. *[N]* flights later he sent you solo into Gloucester. His line: **"slow is smooth, and smooth is fast."**

IF THEY ASK...	OPEN WITH	CLOSE WITH
Difficult feedback	"I was told I wasn't going solo, on the day I expected to."	"I'd been treating speed as competence. It's the opposite — and that was the single biggest thing holding me back."
A failure / setback	"Being held back is a small failure with your name on it and nobody else to blame."	"What changed wasn't my attitude, it was four specific habits. Attitude alone doesn't survive a busy zone."
Your weakness	"When I feel behind, my instinct is to speed up — which is exactly the wrong input."	"It was identified by an instructor, I actively manage it, and I'd rather tell you that than invent something safer."
Managing workload / being behind	"Getting behind the aircraft on the way into a busy zone is a workload problem, not a flying problem."	"Now when I'm behind I slow the inputs and do one thing properly, rather than trying to catch up on all of them."
How you take instruction	"The useful question wasn't 'why not?' — it was 'what specifically do you want to see different?'"	"Vague feedback can't be acted on, so it's partly my responsibility to turn it into something specific."
Hypothetical: failing a progress check	"I've had a version of this already, which is why I'd handle it the same way."	"Raise it immediately, diagnose why rather than just repeating the work, change the method, and use a resit knowingly rather than accidentally."

Drill: "How did you feel when he said it?" · "Have you ever disagreed with an instructor's feedback?" · "You will get a progress check failure at some point — walk me through your first hour after it." · "Is rushing still something you have to manage?"

Why it scores: BA named "learning from feedback" as an assessed area, and flight training is seventy weeks of continuous critique. Being held back and responding well is stronger evidence than passing first time. **This single story answers five separate questions** — feedback, failure, weakness, workload and the progress-check hypothetical. Don't waste it on a question another story covers.

07 · THREE JOBS AT ONCE — BA NAMED THIS AREA IN WRITING

WLM PSD LTW

Status: a situation, not yet a story. Running the business, lifeguarding around forty hours a week, and working through your PPL — with the flying paid out of what you earned, so the hours you worked directly set the rate you could fly at. Excellent raw material, and it currently contains **no decision** — which is the entire competency. "I was very busy and I worked hard" scores nothing. **What you consciously dropped, and when you realised you had to, is what gets marked.**

Answer these five in writing and the story builds itself:

1. Did you ever have to choose between a shift and a lesson? Which won, and **how did you decide?**
2. What did you **stop** doing? (Business marketing, quoting, certain job types, social life, something at school?)
3. Did you turn work down to protect flying, or fly less to protect the business? Which way, and why that way?
4. Did you hand anything over to anyone, or change how you scheduled?
5. **Did you ever decide not to fly because you were too tired after a shift?**

If the answer to (5) is yes, lead with it. That is an airmanship decision, not a diary decision, and it is worth more than the other four combined — you applying a fatigue-management judgement to yourself years before anyone required it of you.

Situation opener: "Over *[period]* I was running my own business, lifeguarding around forty hours a week, and working through my PPL." **Task:** all three competed for the same hours — *[the moment you realised you couldn't hold all of it: a specific week, a cancelled lesson, a job you couldn't service, a bad flight because you were tired]*.

Result & closing line: you finished the PPL in minimum hours and the business kept running — "the useful move wasn't working harder, it was being honest about capacity early enough to still have a choice about what to shed."

Drill: "How do you know you shed the right thing?" · "What if you'd realised two weeks later?" · "Thirteen ATPL exams in twenty-eight weeks with no job around it — how does this apply?" · "What happens to the business during the course?"

Why it will score once filled: deliberately shedding a task and handing it over cleanly is **task-shedding under load**, assessed on the flight deck under that exact name. The self-funding angle also does double duty as motivation evidence.

08 · THE DIFFICULT CUSTOMER — needs your event

COM LTW PSD

BA's FAQ states outright that customer service experience is valuable in cadets, so this is very likely. **Don't reuse the roof tile** — that's your mistake story, and one event serving two questions weakens both.

Situation: one job, one customer, one specific thing that went wrong or was disputed. Two sentences maximum. **Task:** what made it difficult — and **be honest about whether they had a point**. An answer where the customer was simply unreasonable is weaker than one where they were partly right.

Action — the four moves that make this score, in order: (1) **you went to them** rather than waiting to be chased — timing matters more than wording; (2) **you apologised without explaining** — your reasons are true and they're your problem, not theirs; (3) **you asked what would actually help** instead of assuming, and it turned out to be something other than what you'd assumed; (4) **you kept them informed** even with nothing new to say, because silence is what makes waiting feel longer.

Result: what happened, what it cost you, and the closing line — *what worked wasn't the money you gave back, it was finding out what they actually needed.*

Recognition prompts — which actually happened? Someone who disputed the price after the work was done · a customer unhappy with a finish that was genuinely as good as that surface gets, where the job was managing an expectation rather than redoing work · someone who kept adding work beyond the quote · a customer who wanted you to reach something you couldn't safely access and wasn't happy being told no · a complaint about mess, overspray, water or access, theirs or a neighbour's · a late or withheld payment chased without burning the relationship · someone rude or dismissive because of your age · from lifeguarding, a parent who argued about a rule or a swimmer you removed from the water.

Note the fourth prompt. "A customer who wanted you to reach something you couldn't safely access, and wasn't happy being told no" isn't really a customer-service story — **it's a second safety story**, and a commercially costly one. If that happened, it may be worth more than the answer it's sitting in. Flag it to yourself separately.

Why it maps to the flight deck: almost one-for-one with a delay down the back — go to people rather than wait, don't excuse, find the real constraint, give honest timings, and keep talking when there's no news. **If you land that parallel at all, do it in one sentence.**

The reserves — build at least two before the call

These are the difference between a bank that survives twelve questions and one that runs dry at eight. In priority order.

RESERVE	COVERS	WHAT TO LOOK FOR IN THE MEMORY
1 · Army cadets	LTW, away-from-home, followership	How long, camps and exercises, any rank held, a time you were led by someone you disagreed with, a time you were responsible for someone younger. This is your honest answer to "you'll be away from home for months." An honest cadets answer beats a padded expedition story, which always fails at the second follow-up.
2 · HGV workshop	PRO, SAW — a second safety story	A defect someone wanted to defer. If that happened it is close to perfect: commercial pressure against a safety judgement, in a regulated industry, on a vehicle that goes on public roads. It would free the winch cable for a different question.
3 · Kitchen	COM, LTW — conflict	A disagreement handled without becoming personal; working with someone you found difficult; sustained pressure with no ability to stop the flow of work. You have no conflict story and it is a named gap.
4 · Club service winch driving, cable retrieving	LTW, followership, volunteering	BA names volunteering as an acceptable source and their FAQ calls it a strong addition. Frame it once, explicitly, as unpaid service that keeps an operation running. A busy launch point is also your reserve teamwork story if the reception incident is spent.
5 · The Waterside group exercise	Self-awareness	You did it days ago. What would you do differently? The best-evidenced self-awareness answer available to you, and nobody else can offer one this fresh. Two sentences.
6 · Building the business	Pride, resilience, commercial maturity	For "something you're proud of" this beats a flying achievement — motivation, resilience and commercial maturity at once, and it's the engine that funded everything else.
7 · Nine exams, one a month	KNO, study method	Your method, then the scaling arithmetic in A5. Your feedback is explicit that <i>explaining how you approach learning</i> is what separates strong candidates.
Backup safety	SAW	Stopping a launch after spotting an aircraft low over the runway threshold. <i>[Were you in the glider or on the ground, and who made the final call?]</i>

EXECUTION

Doing rather than knowing. The full question bank, what to ask them, how to deliver it, and the week's rehearsal.

C1

The full question bank

Competency questions arrive in four shapes: "tell us about a time when...", "describe a way in which...", "how do you cope when...", and "what would you do if...". The first two want a story. The second two want your reasoning.

Motivation and opening

QUESTION	ANSWER WITH
Tell us about yourself	Set piece A3/1. Ninety seconds, three beats. Rehearse hardest.
Why do you want to be a pilot?	Set piece A3/2. Origin plus an adult reason.
Why British Airways?	Set piece A3/3. Flag carrier, network scale, progression after the freeze, £7bn. Then the personal hook, once.
Why Skyborne over FTEJerez?	Set piece A3/4. Club-to-airline argument plus Bournemouth's commercial exposure.
Why integrated rather than modular?	A3/4 box. You've done modular in miniature and know what it costs in continuity.
What have you done to prepare for this career?	Gliding from thirteen, solo at fourteen, ~100 hrs, five types, bursaries won on merit, winch driving as club service, PPL in minimum hours, nine exams first time — all self-funded. Deliver as a sequence, not a list.
What do you think a short-haul FO actually does day to day?	Early starts and late finishes, four sectors, tight turnarounds, weather and disruption, a different crew most days. Then the part most candidates miss: a highly regulated environment, SOPs, recurrent training and checking throughout your career, fatigue management, professional standards. Your feedback flagged exactly this.
What made you choose gliding, and what has it given you?	Energy management without an engine, decisions about when to come home, reading weather properly, and a club culture where you earn your flying by driving the winch. Airmanship learned from the ground up rather than bought.
You run a business — why not stay with that?	Don't disown it. It was always partly a means to fund flying, it taught you things you wouldn't otherwise have learned, and flying is the career.
What do your family think?	They're checking you've had the real conversations, particularly about six months abroad. Say that you have, and be specific.
If you don't get a place this year?	Set piece A3/5. Accelerates a plan already running.
What do you most want us to remember?	Set piece A3/6. Two sentences, then stop.

Competency — route via B1

QUESTION	WHAT THEY'RE TESTING
A time you worked in a team to achieve something difficult	Specific about your own contribution without erasing the team
A time you took the lead when nobody else would	Leadership without authority — persuading, not instructing
A disagreement within a team and how it was resolved	Did you listen first? Did you separate the issue from the person?
Managing several competing priorities	Your prioritisation logic and what you consciously deprioritised
A significant mistake you made	Own it plainly, describe the fix, describe what changed permanently
Difficult feedback you received	Trainability — seventy weeks of continuous critique
A time you failed and recovered	What you changed, not how unfair it was
A quick decision with incomplete information	Show a process: gather, weigh, decide, review
A time you spoke up when something wasn't right	The highest-value story you have

Explaining something complicated to someone who didn't understand	Bonus if you checked they'd understood rather than assuming
An unhappy customer	BA explicitly values customer service experience
Adapting when a plan changed at short notice	Flexibility without panic
Working with someone you found difficult	You'll live with these people for seventy weeks
Following a rule or procedure you found inconvenient	Aviation runs on people following rules when nobody would notice if they didn't
Noticing something before anyone else did	Situation awareness, asked directly
Staying calm when others weren't	Nearly a gift for you
Something you've done that you're proud of	Choose deliberately — the business, not a flying achievement
Putting someone else's needs ahead of your own	Covering a shift; or the winch cable read that way

Commitment and situational judgement

QUESTION	THE SHAPE OF A STRONG ANSWER
Talk us through the course you'd be starting	Five phases in order with locations and durations, ~70 weeks full time, 13 ATPL exams. Don't recite — say which phase you most look forward to and which you expect to find hardest.
What training standards would you have to meet?	85% average, first series, max 3 resits, first-series CPL and ME/IR, max 1 recourse. State plainly, without anxiety.
How would you approach 13 exams in 28 weeks?	Your method plus the scaling argument — A5.
What will be the hardest part for you personally?	"Nothing" is a failing answer. Two honest candidates: the pace of ground school relative to anything you've done, or six months away from a business you built and can't run remotely. Pair with a mitigation.
What happens to your business if you're offered a place?	Near-certain given your application. Hesitation reads as a flight risk. Have a decided answer — paused, handed over, wound down — and say it without wavering.
Six months in Florida, no leave. How will you handle it?	Be honest that you haven't lived away for an extended period. What you do have: a business where nobody above you picks up the slack, a forty-hour week alongside training and study, and <i>[cadets — how long, camps, exercises, any rank]</i> . Then what you'll put in place, and that Florida is six months with a cohort of 8–12 in the same position, not six months alone.
How do you handle stress and stay calm under pressure?	A named strategy plus an example , not an assertion. You've been in situations where the calm was the job — then the reception incident.
What if you failed a progress check or an exam?	Raise it immediately, diagnose why rather than repeating the work, adjust the method, use the resit allowance knowingly. Gloucester is your evidence.
Strengths and weaknesses?	A real weakness with an active remedy. Not "I'm a perfectionist." Yours is true and available: a tendency to rush when you feel behind, identified by an instructor, actively managed.
Where do you see yourself in ten years?	Compatible with a six-year short-haul freeze: through the freeze, potentially long-haul, possibly working towards a training role. Don't say "captain by thirty" — that timeline isn't yours to set.
Why should we give you one of these places?	Don't list adjectives. Three sentences: you've proved you can pass exams to a standard on a schedule; you've proved you make the safe call when it costs you personally; and you've paid for every hour yourself, which tells them what happens when it gets hard.
A fellow cadet is struggling and falling behind	Support first — study together, find out what's actually wrong. Escalate to staff if it's beyond peer help, and be clear that isn't disloyalty. In a cohort of 8–12 you can't ignore it.
A classmate has been drinking the night before an early flight	Unambiguous: speak to them directly, then report. Say it without hedging — soften the manner if you like, never the outcome.
Your instructor gives feedback you think is wrong	Ask first to understand what they saw — they usually saw something you didn't. Then put your view respectfully and accept the outcome. Note you've been on the receiving end of feedback you initially disagreed with and were wrong about.
Rooming with someone you don't get on with, for months	Raise it early, directly and privately, before it calcifies. Look for the practical fix rather than the moral argument. Involve staff only if it starts affecting training.

Running late and you realise you've missed a checklist item	Stop, go back, complete it. The whole point of the 85% standard and the first-series rule is that this industry doesn't trade accuracy for speed. Slow is smooth, smooth is fast.
Being told what to do by people much older or younger than you	You've done both — a gliding club is full of people decades older, and you run a business where you direct the work. Say that.
Allocated to Euroflyer at Gatwick rather than BA at Heathrow?	A5 box. Never disappointment.
What's caught your eye in aviation recently?	Find it yourself in the week before — A5.

C2

Questions to ask the panel

The call ends on your questions. A flat finish undoes good work — and a genuinely good question is one of the few moments where you can visibly out-prepare the field. **Have four ready; you'll likely ask two, and one may get answered along the way.** Ask about the training and the life — it shows you're picturing yourself doing it.

ASK	WHY IT WORKS
1 • Cohort dynamics — the best one. "I saw that Speedbird cohorts here are only eight to twelve. That's small enough that the group itself must make a real difference — what does a cohort that works well look like, and is there anything a cadet can do to make theirs one of those?"	Proves you read past the marketing into the FAQ; shows you think about groups rather than only yourself — the group-exercise competency reappearing unprompted; and invites them to talk about something they care about. Almost nobody asks it.
2 • The 85% standard, from the right angle. "What separates the cadets who thrive in ground school from the ones who find the 85% first-series standard hard? Is it usually study method, or something else?"	Identifies the binding constraint of the whole course and asks people who've watched dozens meet or miss it. The "or something else" clause is what makes it good — it signals you suspect the answer isn't simply "work harder".
3 • Coachability, made visible. "What's the most common piece of feedback your instructors find themselves giving first-phase cadets?"	You're asking to be corrected before you've started. After a story about being held back and fixing the habit, it lands as consistent rather than performative — and the answer is genuinely useful.
4 • Forward planning. "What would you want me to have done between now and day one — and are there administrative things for the Florida phase, visa or medical validation, worth getting ahead of?"	Assumes competence without arrogance, and the second half shows you've thought about the machinery of a six-month overseas phase rather than just the flying.

Strong alternatives: "How does the transition from Gloucestershire to Vero Beach work in practice, and what do cadets typically find hardest about it?" · "How does the APS MCC phase differ from a standard MCC, and how directly does it feed into a BA type rating?" · "You've now run several Speedbird cohorts — has anything changed in how you prepare cadets based on what you learned from the first ones?" (**very strong if the panel includes a training captain**) · "I've come up through gliding and a club environment. Is there anything about that background that helps, or anything it tends to leave gaps in?"

Do not ask: "How did I do?" — puts them on the spot, reads as insecure · "What are the next steps?" — you already know; signals you haven't read the process · **salary, bond or leave** — this is the school, not HR, and it shifts the frame from vocation to transaction · anything answerable from their website.

C3

Delivery and technical setup

HOW PEOPLE FAIL THIS STAGE

FAILURE MODE	WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE
"We" instead of "I"	The collective voice leaves the assessor nothing to score
Setup-heavy stories	Three minutes of background, then the action in one sentence
Borrowed motivation	"I've always wanted to fly" with nothing behind it

SETUP — TEST DAYS BEFOREHAND

- ☐ Test Teams on the actual device days beforehand. Sign in with your full proper name.
- ☐ Wired ethernet if possible; otherwise sit close to the router and get everyone else off the wifi.
- ☐ Phone hotspot ready as a fallback, and the interview contact details **written on paper.**
- ☐ Camera at eye level — stack books under the laptop. Looking down at people is the commonest and least flattering error.
- ☐ Light from in front, not behind. Nothing bright at your back.

Fake weaknesses	"I work too hard" reads as unwillingness to be honest — a genuine flag in a training environment
Vagueness about the school	Reads as though any flight school would do
Underestimating the commitment	Waving away the relocation, the no-leave course, or the 85% standard
Wobbling under follow-up	Fluent for two minutes, then unable to defend it. Composure when challenged is the assertiveness competency.
Treating it as a formality	Arriving mentally already at Stage 3. It's a real gate.
A flat finish	No questions, or a weak one, on a call that ends on your questions

- ☐ Plain, tidy background. Real beats virtual.
- ☐ Headphones with a microphone beat laptop audio. Record a test and listen back.
- ☐ Do-not-disturb on every device; close everything else.
- ☐ Full business dress, exactly as for Waterside — and dressed properly from the waist down in case you stand.
- ☐ Join five minutes early and wait in the lobby.

PRESENTATION

- ☐ **Look at the lens when you speak, at the faces when you listen.** It reads as eye contact.
- ☐ One page of bullet prompts beside the screen — never read from. Better: a sticky note with your eight story titles.
- ☐ **Slow down about 15%.** Video swallows fast speech; deliberate delivery reads as composed.
- ☐ "May I take a moment to think about that" is entirely fine. It reads as considered.
- ☐ Positive, open body language — your ATPL feedback names it explicitly. Sit up, hands visible, don't fold your arms.
- ☐ If the connection drops, rejoin and carry on. They've seen it many times.

C4

Rehearsal plan

WHEN	WHAT
Tonight	Answer the five questions in B2/07 in writing. Fill every bracket in stories 01–06. Confirm the April-pack stories are real memories or discard them.
Day 2	Identify the difficult-customer event. Mine cadets and the HGV workshop for the two priority reserves. Two sentences on the Waterside group exercise.
Day 3	Say every story aloud, timed. Over two minutes: cut the Situation, never the Action. Under forty seconds is underweight.
Day 4	Moulds only. Take one story and answer four different questions with it, changing only the opening and closing lines. This is the session that makes the bank flexible.
Day 5	Full 45-minute mock on Teams, dressed as on the day, using the sheet below. A comfortable mock is a wasted mock.
Day 6	Find your current aviation story yourself. Set pieces aloud three times each. Test the tech.
Night before	Read the cram card and nothing else. Stop preparing.

Mock interview sheet — hand this page to whoever runs it

Instructions for the person asking. Do the full 45 minutes, on Teams, with him dressed as he would be on the day. **Ask in random order** — don't work down the list. After every story answer, ask at least one follow-up: *"What would you have done differently?"* · *"What if that hadn't worked?"* · *"Why did you do it that way?"* Time each answer and flag anything over two minutes or under forty seconds. Note whether he says "I" or "we" in the action part. **Be blunt afterwards.**

1. Tell me about yourself. · 2. Why do you want to be a pilot? · 3. Why British Airways? · 4. Why Skyborne rather than FTEJerez? · 5. Tell me about a time you spoke up when something wasn't right. · 6. A time you worked in a team to achieve something difficult. · 7. An example of managing several competing priorities. · 8. A significant mistake you made. · 9. A time you got difficult feedback. · 10. A quick decision without full information. · 11. An unhappy customer you dealt with. · 12. What's the hardest part of this course going to be for you? · 13. What training standards would you have to meet? · 14. How would you approach thirteen exams in twenty-eight weeks? · 15. You're a new First Officer. The Captain briefs an approach you think is wrong. You say so once and he dismisses it. What now? · 16. A Captain you fly with often makes small deviations from SOPs. What do you do? · 17. A fellow cadet is falling behind. What do you do? · 18. What happens to your business if you get a place? · 19. Six months in Florida, no leave. How will you handle that? · 20. What would you do if you didn't get a place? · 21. What's your biggest weakness? · 22. What's caught your eye in aviation recently? · 23. Where do you see yourself in ten years? · 24. What do you most want us to remember about you? · 25. What questions do you have for us?

FACT-CHECK RECORD

What was verified, what was corrected, and how confident to be. The body of this booklet already states the corrected version — this page records the working.

Corrections applied

ITEM	BRIEF V3 SAID	CORRECTED TO
Aeros	"Appears to support the self-sponsored pathway"	Wrong. Aeros is a selected partner delivering elements of training within the fully funded 2026 Academy , via a modular route (Fast-Track / Flexi-Track) for candidates who hold or are working toward modular ratings. The 2026 Academy is exclusively fully funded. BA separately runs a <i>Speedbird Self-Sponsored Pathway</i> — a different scheme, and the likely source of the confusion. Consequence: "why integrated rather than modular?" is a live question for you because you hold a PPL. Answer drafted in A3/4.
Applicants	"25,000+ in previous years"	Sources support "tens of thousands" and "over 20,000" for 2026. Say "over twenty thousand" — don't quote 25,000 as fact.
Graduates	"Fewer than 50 to date"	BA's April 2026 wording is "nearly 50 pilots have graduated and integrated into flight deck operations." Same number; sounds like momentum rather than scarcity.
Phase durations	28 + 26 + 9.5 + 0.5 + 3, alongside "70 weeks"	That sums to 67. The balance is transitions and phase gaps. Quote the phases or the total, not both in a way that invites the subtraction.
Added	ATPL theory validity not stated	13 exams within 18 months of first attempt (max 4 attempts per subject, 6 sittings); passes valid 36 months for CPL/IR issue. Your scholarship panel probed this. Now in A5.

Verified and correct

Skyborne founded 2016 by Lee Woodward with Tom Misner — Woodward CEO, Misner chairman, Ian Cooper COO, both Woodward and Cooper ex-airline with senior roles at other academies · Gloucestershire (Staverton) HQ, Bournemouth second base, Vero Beach acquisition completed May 2021 · course phases 28 weeks theory, 26 weeks single-engine/CPL at Vero Beach, ~10 weeks ME/IR · ground school standard of first-series pass at 85% average, max 3 resits, first-series CPL and ME/IR, max 1 recourse, and BA's stated right to withdraw the conditional offer · starting salary £37,081 plus allowances · six-year short-haul fleet freeze with bidding between BA and Euroflyer · allocation on business need · £18m and up to 160 places for 2026, fourth year running, ~£100,000 per cadet · Sean Doyle Chairman & CEO, Simon Cheadle Director of Flight Operations · 13 UK CAA ATPL exams · nine PPL exams · the nine EASA/ICAO pilot competencies · PACE, TEM, just culture and normalisation of deviance all correctly described · cohort size 8–12 · fleet and simulator details.

Confidence and caveats

CATEGORY	NOTE
Official and verified	Stages, training standards, salary, leave, fleet freeze, allocation, accommodation, medical, course phases, cohort size and eligibility come from BA's Speedbird Pilot Academy FAQ (14 April 2026), BA's media centre release of the same date, BA careers preparation pages, and Skyborne's own site. Re-checked 14 August 2026.
From your own documents	The six assessed areas, the 45-minute duration and the STAR recommendation come from your BA invitation email. PACE, the two scenarios, the four assessment areas and the communication guidance come from your 2026 ATPL Scholarship feedback letter — a generic template issued to all unsuccessful candidates, not an individual assessment of your interview. Treat its descriptions of strong answers as the bar to clear, not as criticism.
Unconfirmed — do not assert	The training bond. Widely reported, absent from BA's published FAQ. BA does state the training is worth roughly £100,000 per cadet. Don't raise it in the interview.
What doesn't exist	No verbatim first-hand account of this specific Skyborne Teams interview is public. The question bank is built from the competencies BA and Skyborne state they assess, your invitation email, your ATPL feedback, and the standard structure of airline cadet competency interviews. Expect the shape to be right and the exact wording to differ.
Your own material	Stories and biographical detail come from Interview Brief v3. Bracketed details remain yours to fill from memory. The April 2026 interview pack describes a different set of experiences and should not be used unless independently confirmed as real.

Primary references. BA Speedbird Pilot Academy invitation email and 2026 ATPL Scholarship feedback letter (your own) · BA Speedbird Pilot Academy FAQs, 14 April 2026 · BA Media Centre, fully-funded pilot training programme opens for a fourth year, 14 April 2026 · BA Careers, Speedbird application preparation · Skyborne — Speedbird pages, Speedbird FAQs, UK training facilities, UK fleet, accommodation · Aeros Flight Training and FLYER / AFM Aero coverage of the Aeros partnership · Businesswire, Skyborne completion of Vero Beach acquisition, May 2021 · Punchline Gloucester and Insider Media on Skyborne's founding and leadership · UK Civil Aviation Authority, ATPL(A) and PPL(A) licensing and theoretical knowledge validity · EASA Flight Examiner Manual and IATA CBTA guidance for the nine-competency framework.

PREPARED FOR JAMES GEORGE · 14 AUGUST 2026 · EVERYTHING IN HIGHLIGHTED BRACKETS IS YOURS TO FILL
FROM MEMORY